and it is astonishing that it survived in isolation for so long in India[7]. Unfortunately, the Portuguese tried to forcibly eradicate Jewish customs, including the language, and replace them with Catholic ones in the sixteenth century. Nonetheless, some ancient traditions live on in the Syrian Christian community.

As one can see, the legacy of the ancient trade-routes is still very much alive and is yet another example of India's astonishing ability to maintain civilizational continuities. If Cleopatra had made good her escape, we would probably have a group that directly traced its origins to the Egyptian queen and Julius Caesar. It is still possible to experience the atmosphere of those times in the older parts of Kochi (Cochin). Pepper, ginger and other spices are still warehoused and traded in the bylanes. Deals are sometimes negotiated using a system of hand signals, hidden from onlookers by a cloth, that evolved centuries ago. Sitting in the toddy-shop, I watch modern ships ply in the harbour. I imagine myself as Hippalus, the ancient Greek mariner, enjoying his first drink after months at sea. Not far is 'Jew Town' where a tiny Jewish community lives clustered around a sixteenth-century synagogue. The Jews must have been held in high esteem by King Rama Varma for he allowed the construction of the synagogue right next to his palace. Sadly, the community has been sharply depleted in recent decades by emigration to Israel.

TO THE ISLAND OF GOLD

Even as the western coast traded with the Middle East and the Graeco–Roman world, the eastern coast of India saw a similar boom in trade with South-East Asia and all the way to China. There were dozens of ports all along the coast including the great port of Tamralipti in Bengal, the cluster of ports around Chilka lake in Orissa (recently renamed Odisha), the Pallava port of Mahabalipuram and the Chola port of Nagapattinam. Note that I am generalizing about a very long period of time and the relative importance of the various ports waxed and waned over the centuries.